

29-01-25

HUL272 - sociology - Lec 08

- Functionalist is a general concept Perspective

- views society as a complex system of inter-connected parts working together to maintain stability (stasis/equilibrium) and social order
- In the context of Indian villages: [discussed in lec 07]
 - Tajman / patron-client system / relation
 - Caste system for segmenting various functions
 - units for endogamy
 - common occupations
- keep the "village" system well functioning

- Critique of - From the Episode of Panchayat Functionalist Perspective narrative Trope

Driven by "Sachiv-gi"

- An urban "outsider" who is now stuck and officially an "insider" in a village
 - official of Govt.
 - Connects with "Pradhani" (and his family), "Sahayak", "Prahlad"; etc.
- No emotional connect with village as a unit
- more objectified views on the events (Atleast in Season 1 start)

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* चक्के वाली कुर्सी = the stool with wheels //

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- Power Dynamics → Multiple Power Hierarchies of Phulera visible throughout the episode (and series)

Pradhan &

Sachiv - Pradhan

• Baarati's

Pradhan - Puti

• The seat* bought by Sachiv ji sought to change

• Gharati's

official post filled by a female but power exercised by her husband

the optics of power - Hierarchy in eyes of villagers and Pradhan

• The bride-takers assume and are treated with more respect and power by the bride-givers

• Pradhan has to exert dominance by forcing Sachiv ji to give into demands throughout episode

and also ends up buying the same "wheeled" chair at the end once Sachiv ji loses it.

Eg: 5 sweets/box for villagers and 7 sweets/box for Groom side "Baratis"

Using of Public Infrastructure Sachiv - Bride (School is Pradhan office)

• The "fight" that ended up in Sachiv-j's losing ownership

• Not possible for those that are not close to the person that holds the power (here Pradhan)

• Parmeshwar of the wheeled-chain* was influential [Also had a brick laying business] so could get access [By virtue of being closer to Pradhan]

- Functionalist view doesn't emphasize on such conflicts {Evident from above}

- Exploring "Conflict & Change" - Marxist approach

to view Indian villages and critique Functionalist view

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"It is not the consciousness of men that determines their existence, but their social existence that determines their consciousness" — Marx

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• What is a class?



• A group of people who share similar conditions of life in relation of life to the means of production

• An economic classification to create strata's in society

• means

Physical, non-human inputs used in production

• (Agricultural) Land & Natural Resources

• Tools

Machinery; Factories

• Infrastructure

(Road; Energy / Power systems)

→ Marx view conflicting Hegles view

Hegles view

of Historical changes

• Driven by conflict of ideas

• ultimate spf force : "Geist" of change

[An absolute spirit common to all men]

• Social change is a process of:

(i) Thesis → (ii) Anti-thesis → (iii) Synthesis

[Final Idea incorporates changes made to initial idea by virtue of opposing idea]

Marx's Critique : Materialism : The basic material conditions drive changes not ideas

• Social Progress as a result of conflict

[Eg: Raw materials used in Houses depend on what is available]

between economic classes

[discussed later]

(not ideas)

• Historical materialism:

"Base" of society

→ Determines ideological "super-structure"

not the other way around

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"The proletarians have nothing to lose but their chains" - Marx

tried with social change in capitalist society

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- Mode of Production is a function of "Relation of Production" and "Means of Production"

① Mode of - The way in which a society organises its economic activity
(Eg: Capitalism, Feudalism, Socialism)
and is driven by 2 ideas / constructs

② Relations of Production

- The social relationships of people involved in process of production

• ownership of means of production

• distribution of labour, resources & wealth

[Human ↔ Human]

③ Means of Production

• reflects the sum of all physical, non-human inputs used in production

like :

Eg: Bourgeoisie (owner of means of production)

mostly privately owned

Proletariat (those who provide labour in capitalism)

by bourgeoisie in capitalism

(i) land & Natural Resources
(ii) Tools, Factory and Machinery

along with Technological know-how

(iii) Infrastructure like roads & power-system

Feudal lords - serfs [in feudalism]

- Radical Socialist change as envisioned by Marx in a capitalist society

① Capitalists function to maximize profits

② constancy of wages & constant other costs

• stagnant wages - maintain margins

• other production costs once minimized are almost constant (by virtue of available means of production)

(i) Prioritize profit

(ii) Extract maximum value from worker

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"Chains" - A metaphor for deep rooted exploitation of the working class

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③ Increased working hours → (i) Boost profits by increasing working time of workers

→ (ii) More labour & same pay

④ Dehumanization of worker class :

(i) long work hours repetitive tasks ↔ a machine analogy (ii) Exploitation may go un-noticed early on / before a threshold

⑤ High exploitation results in violent social uprising

• conditions worsen ⇒ • workers develop class consciousness, recognize shared interests & organize

• Exploitation over a threshold sparks a revolution

→ Conclude that "Conflicts are endemic to society" ① There always exist structural inequalities in society
↓ ↓ ↓
class division gender caste

② Dominant groups will exploit the weaker groups in order to maximize their interests

③ The oppression becomes a driving force for social change or may be even a revolution

→ Analysing Indian villages by the Marxist notion of class

(P.T.O)

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Dominant class

Exploited class

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- case of zamindars and Agricultural workers (Landlords)

• ownership of means of production



Agricultural land ownership

relation

← of production →

• Don't own lands ⇒ Forced to work on the lands of zamindars

• Intermediaries in tax collection [during British Raj] causing concentration of wealth

Base →

← economic class

distinction

• Forced to pay taxes to the zamindars

→ Analysing why India didn't have a radical socialist revolution [compared to China / Soviet Union]

• Marx's Idea of class consciousness fails because of the caste identities and religious identities which dominated over class identity

↳ • Hence exploitation didn't force people close enough to spark a revolution

PS : → Lingering effects of Indian politics and political parties

Religion & Caste v.s. class

↓ developed around caste

primarily religious [BSP, AIMIM] identities

as well as it is the de-facto standard of mobilisation of votes during elections and not class

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whereas many European countries tend to have a "Workers party" / "socialist party" where class consciousness had emerged throughout its history of socialist movement

→ Caste - Class Correlation - Analysed Indian society from "bottom-up" by Jan Mencher

• concludes that caste system's ~~one~~ has an (un)intended side effect of economic exploitation ^{can be debated-upon?} of lower castes rather than promoting inter-dependence and reciprocity

• suppression → prevent access to certain resources → village well; Education; Etc
→ Access to land ownership

• concentration of wealth & economic power } By the virtue of being the dominant caste generally [upper-castes]

→ Pre and Post Independence changes in lives of pawns
→ (i) Land ownership (patterns)
→ (ii) Inheritance (ii) Buying
→ Impossible since accessory lineage was forced to never own lands → (After Independence) mostly poor, so very unlikely

→ (ii) Access to Political Power
→ (i) Pre-Independence → Not possible as not the dominant caste (generally)

→ (ii) Post-Independence
→ Had access vis a vis separate electorates for the pawns; giving rise to share of pawns in political system of country

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Hence in context of Indian villages :
caste → social hierarchy
class → economic hierarchy

→ Similarity of Ambedkar and Mencher's views → Ambedkar's view at caste system in village as

a "Site of oppression"

• Division into "touchables" and "untouchables" with clear power dynamics and economic hierarchy

• Rejected Functionalist view and argued it as "Empire of Hindu over" untouchables

Deeply positively related to Mencher's findings

→ Earlier Sociological Focus on Caste [In Indian context] v.s. → Recent Sociological Focus on class (~10-15 years)

AS explained before

• Earmarked by Rise of Middle class and changing of economic structure

• Shift in resource & Goods availability due to Globalisation

proves
• Changing Consumption patterns

Eg: poor class → middle class

Choice of vehicle	2 wheeler/ Bicycle	4 wheeler
Choice of clothes	cheap, local	named brands

Etc.

→ class status optics
→ visible changes in lifestyle like food, consumer goods, education are an indicator of social position

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